

■ Kimi Dangor and Jhilmil Motihar

If one fashion editor can make a fashion week, the organisers of Lakme Fashion Week (LFW) have a winner on their hands. Suzy Menkes, fashion editor of *International Herald Tribune* is all set to grace the front row at this Mumbai event. This may sound like the Lakme-IMG combine's answer to the Fashion Design Council of India's trendy tryst with feathered fashion diva, the late Isabella Blow, but Menkes' impending arrival and *International Herald Tribune's* hallowed presence is definitely creating a buzz in ateliers across the country. And while the global style glory that the LFW folks dream of may be several seasons away, it will surely keep this event's seasonal showing from becoming just another city-centric clothes call.

Thanks to overpowering competition from the capital's couture circles, Anil Chopra and his comrades at IMG are pulling out all stops to make sure curtains don't go down on their fashion spectacle. With a depleting arsenal of established names like Arjun Khanna, Manish Malhotra, Sabyasachi Mukherjee, Narendra Kumar, Kiran Uttam Ghosh, Krishna Mehta and Wendell Rodricks, LFW is treading tricky trend territory. But Lakme's marketing minds and IMG's fashion folks are all set to add more frills to the event. Besides Menkes's presence, LFW's foreign flanks will be strengthened by Laurie De Jong, who returns as venue director and stylist Caterina Scardino. "Anu Athri from the fashion forecasting company WGSN will be visiting the event for the first time," says Vikram Raizada, VP and fashion head, IMG.

The event that has acted as a launch pad for many of India's emerging talents is pushing forward the mentor mantra and is poised to launch eight new labels this season under the GenNext category. With last year's debutantes like Kallol Dutta and Rimzim Dadu having moved on to the emerging category, a new line of designers is set to take

their spot in the style-light. And LFW's alternate lobby of stars, a motley troupe of trendsetters nurtured over the last few seasons, is all set to stamp the event with their signature statements. Names like Anupama Dayal, Dev r Nil, Nachiket Barve, Vineet Bahl, Drashta Sarvaiya and Kaushie Adiseshan, who have emerged as formidable fashion forces over the last few seasons, are ready to front the fashion event. Their level of

confidence is contagious. Barve, readying for his third show at the fashion week, says, "For a new label, this event is a fantastic platform to be out there in the public arena. A few years ago, it would have taken a lot more time to make buyers aware of my existence."

With new names cropping up every season from Haryana, Kolkata, Delhi, Ahmedabad, Bangalore and Mumbai, LFW's pan-India persuasion promises to infuse the fashion scene with some

FRESH TAKE

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Drashta Sarvaiya

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Dev r Nil

Their line Pixel Dreams symbolises femininity with floaty frocks

